Connecting Threads: Creating a Participatory and Globally Accessible Platform for the Study of Checked Indian Cotton Textiles

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Introduction

Connecting Threads is an international collaborative digital history project dedicated to amplifying the contributions of Indian weavers and African Caribbean consumers to global histories of dress. Drawing on the work of an interdisciplinary team of researchers, this project re-examines the history of the Madras handkerchief, an internationally popular dress accessory made of brightly colored checked cotton. Through archival and object research and using digital humanities tools and methodologies, our project investigates the contributions of people of color to global fashion histories. In the first phase of the project (completed in October 2024), we focused on the labor politics of textile artisans in southern India and the creativity of consumers of African descent in the Greater Caribbean Region that includes countries of the Caribbean as well as parts of southeastern United States and South America. In so doing, we explored a south-to-south connection that has been largely ignored in global fashion history.

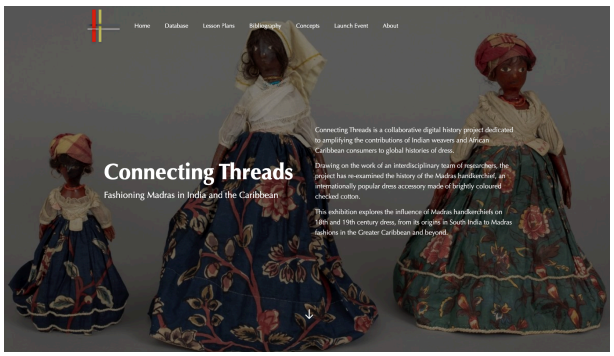

Figure 1. The homepage of the Connecting Threads Website

Project Background and Significance

Over the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, handmade Indian cotton textiles and their European mill-made imitations infiltrated markets all over the world, driving radical shifts in global fashion. The circulation of Indian and Indian-imitation cottons in this period has received considerable scholarly attention; however, there has historically been an imbalanced focus on White Euro-American traders and consumers as drivers of change in global systems of production and trade. The roles and impacts of other markets for Indian and Indian-imitation cottons -- particularly those of the Global South -- are comparatively underrepresented. This lack of representation restricts public explorations of this important chapter in fashion history to Euro-centric narratives.

This issue is particularly well-illustrated by the history of the Madras handkerchief, a large cotton kerchief patterned with multi-colored checks. South Indian weavers creatively adapted the patterns of Madras kerchiefs to suit the tastes of different markets abroad, including markets in the Americas. Eighteenth- and nineteenth-century textual records and visual art show that Madras kerchiefs were especially popular in the Greater Caribbean Region where they allowed both free and enslaved Black women and men to express themselves in a context in which they had limited choice and agency. Today Madras remains an important element of cultural dress for many in the region, used to express collective identities and shared histories. Yet the origins and development of Black Caribbean and wider American tastes for Madras, the creative role of South Indian weavers in supplying those tastes, and the larger impacts of the South Indian-Caribbean/American relationship on global fashion are poorly understood. The Madras story -- like many other Global South fashion exchanges -- has seldom been explored by cultural or educational institutions engaged in public history for this reason, and academic scholar-

ship on textiles like Madras has tended to focus on it as an economic trade good as opposed to an article of fashion.

Digital Humanities Approach and Methodology

When we started envisioning this project in 2021, we consciously designed it as a born-digital public-facing history project that produces original research and uses DH tools and methods to collate, analyze, and disseminate our findings. We found this important to our research and pedagogical practice as this project, while generated within the western academy, studies communities of the Global South with very little written histories, especially in a transcultural or transnational context. We therefore aimed this project's audience to be people from the communities that we studied---in South India and in the Greater Caribbean---and their diaspora.

Johanna Drucker (2012) has described "humanistic approaches to visualization," which emphasize interpretation, context, and ambiguity rather than positivistic data representation. This approach acknowledges that historical data---particularly concerning marginalized communities---is often fragmentary, contested, and shaped by colonial power dynamics. By making our interpretative processes visible alongside the data itself, we make this fragmentation visible even as we are primarily making use of colonial archives since indigenous textual archives do not exist.

Our intention with this project is also to make Connecting Threads a platform that can be a "hub" for textile practitioners, scholars, and community stakeholders to use as a repository for their collections and history, since most regions that we study do not have ample institutional systems that can support the necessary digital infrastructure.

Project Components and Infrastructure

In the first phase of the project, we designed three main open access components: a database that made all our primary source research accessible to the public including transcriptions and translations of records in English, French, and Spanish---the main languages of the colonial archives where these records exist; a digital exhibition that uses project research findings to explore the influence of Madras handkerchiefs on 18th and 19th century dress. The story begins with the origins of Madras in South India before exploring Madras fashions in the Greater Caribbean, and the impact of those fashions in Europe and beyond. The database includes object and archival records we have examined from 2022-2024. In addition, the five lesson plans we created provide guidance to educators who want to make use of this project and associated research materials in their classrooms. You can access all these resources on our website: https://connectingthreads.co.uk/

The project's pilot proposal was first developed in 2021 in collaboration with The Smithsonian Cooper-Hewitt Design Museum, the Victoria & Albert Museum, and The University of Glasgow Special Collections and Archives as institutional partners. The open-access databases of these institutions were used to test the data API approach that is the backbone of the Connecting Threads digital infrastructure. In 2023, the project welcomed two new regional museum partners, the Louisiana State Museums in the US and Bristol Museums and Archives in the UK, and we are currently in talks with more museums. Further data has been collected independently from a range of institutions across Europe and America. (For a working list of institutions, we have collected data from so far, please see our website.) We are presently working on collaborations with regional museums in India.

We are currently in the second phase of the project. In this phase, our focus is to digitally "connect" objects and archival records from our partnering archive and museum institutions. The expected outputs include: an expansion of the PostgreSQL database built on a custom API web crawler which also has manual data entry options; a front-end platform built on Django capable of operating as a public-facing collections catalog for institutional collaborators whose collections are not otherwise accessible online; and interactive visualizations for the public that combine primary sources with data analysis and research generated using the database.

Decolonial Approaches to Digital Infrastructure

The project, as described above, is founded on the principle of democratizing access to digital infrastructure and building equity into the practice of Digital Humanities. Drawing on Kim Christen's (2012) work on indigenous archives and digital repatriation, we recognize that digital platforms can either reinforce or challenge colonial information hierarchies. Thus, the project's decolonial research approach extends through its digital architecture, which enables equitable access for both users and institutions. This architectural approach is informed by what Roopika Risam (2019) terms "digital humanities of resistance," which challenges the technological determinism and Global North dominance of much digital scholarship.

Importantly, by connecting the collections of national institutions with those of state and municipal institutions, the project promotes and affirms the value of regionally- and locally-held collections in data-based historical research---this type of visibility is crucial for smaller institutions struggling to make their collections relevant to a global audience. In this regard, we follow the

objectives initiated by Alex Gil and Élika Ortega (2016), who have argued that digital humanities must develop "minimal computing" approaches that work with rather than against the technological constraints faced by many institutions outside wealthy Western contexts.

As smaller cultural institutions frequently lack the financial resources and digital skills needed to engage in DH, the project's technology stack is designed to enable curators, archivists, and cultural heritage professionals working in resource-strained institutions to become active collaborators on the database, thereby providing a platform for them to share their collections online for the first time. As scholars also within a western academic system studying histories of the Global South, the project team is particularly conscious of an ethical duty to make the project as participatory and inclusive as possible for scholars, practitioners, communities, and diasporas from South Asia and the Caribbean, with the database offering opportunities for training institutional users, especially from these groups.

We designed the website to accommodate varying publics' digital accessibility, learning, and engagement needs by making the data and research accessible in different formats, from downloadable raw data to interpretations and interactive visualizations. By making a technology stack that is replicable and providing a "starter kit" via GitHub, historians, art historians, archivists, and museum professionals will also be empowered to replicate the project's methodology for undertaking their own multi-institutional, multi-medial, data-based research.

Building Communities Through Digital Connection

The project is also literally connecting practitioners and scholars. For our project launch, we put together a symposium at the V&A Museum in London in October 2024. At this day-long event, we brought together scholars of Caribbean fashion and dress, labor historians studying weaver communities in South India, curators and scholar-practitioners who work with Madras textiles, Indian weavers and traders of Madras, and contemporary Caribbean fashion designers and enthusiasts who work with Madras.

This community-building aspect of our work is what Julie Thompson Klein (2015) has termed "boundary crossing scholarship," which creates spaces for transdisciplinary dialogue and knowledge co-creation. By facilitating interactions between scholarly and practitioner communities, we aim to develop spaces where different knowledge systems can engage with one another on more equal terms than traditional academic hierarchies allow.

Data Sovereignty and Future Directions

As we continue with the second phase of the project, we are also looking at questions of data sharing and sovereignty: because the textiles that underpin our study were objects under colonial control, most of the extant textiles and their records exist within colonial archives housed in the West, in the US, UK, and Europe. We are acutely aware of the complexities of ownership of this data. In democratizing access to this history through the Connecting Threads project by making our data, research, and interpretation available to a global public audience, we offer the project as an additional vector point for control over data collection, data ownership, and data sharing.

Our approach to these questions is informed by emerging concepts of "cultural data sovereignty" (Kukutai and Taylor, 2016) and what Jessica Marie Johnson (2018) terms "radical data ethics." These frameworks emphasize that data about historically marginalized communities is not merely information but represents ancestral knowledge and cultural heritage that should be governed according to the values and needs of those communities themselves. By creating infrastructure that enables source communities to access and reinterpret materials held in distant archives, we hope to offer a participatory approach to developing born-digital history projects.

Authors' Note: This paper was originally written in November 2024 when our project had received a new grant from the National Endowment of the Humanities (NEH) to build out its digital infrastructure and participatory aspects outlined below. As of April 01, 2025, the current US federal administration, with the participation of the Department of Government Efficiency (DOGE) headed by Elon Musk, sent notification of premature termination of our grant along with many others. As such, at the time of revising this essay, we are still working out the details of how to continue with this project.

Connecting Threads core project team include Dr. Meha Priyadarshini (University of Edinburgh), Dr. Deepthi Murali (George Mason University), Avalon Fotheringham (Victoria & Albert Museum), Dr. Victoria DeLorenzo (London College of Fashion), Dr. Jason A. Heppler (George Mason University).

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